

Sandhya Devanathan, *46*
Head and vice-president, Meta India

RAJWANT RAWAT

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"If something feels patently wrong, please speak up"

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Delivering Meta Equality

IN NOVEMBER 2022, when Sandhya Devanathan took charge as the India head of Meta, the parent company of Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp was in tumult. It faced regulatory challenges and criticism for doing little to curb fake news and hate speech. The company had laid off 11,000 employees globally.

A year later, Sandhya is proud of what her "Meta family at work" has achieved. "The biggest success has been how the team has put behind those setbacks and went ahead with a sense of purpose, which is the big India vision," she says. Meta has not only clocked higher revenues in India but also introduced innovative programmes. "We don't take the privilege to connect half a billion people lightly. That's why we are doubling down on initiatives to keep Meta platforms safe, particularly for women and children, and free from misinformation," she says.

After an illustrious banking career with Citibank and Standard Chartered, she joined Meta as group director, Southeast Asia, in Singapore in January 2016. By August 2016, she was then made the first ever country director of Meta in Singapore and business head of Vietnam.

Sandhya is passionate about developing women leaders in business. "I want Meta to become a participant in the journey of India, which is at the cusp of a transformation. I want more women to take part in making that happen," she says. She herself faced the pressure of being a woman professional, more so when she became a mother. She had little support in New York, where she was working. Yet she did not drop out. "It is important to stick on," she says.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
She is a leading light in women's empowerment in education and tech workplaces

Born to banker parents, Sandhya lost her mother when she was just nine and her younger sister six. The family moved from Hyderabad to Visakhapatnam, where her grandmother and aunt helped her father bring up the two sisters. "So much of my life has been shaped by these strong women," she says.

Currently, she is on the Global Diversity Equity Council of Meta, and was global lead for Play Forward, a Meta initiative to improve gender diversity in gaming. "There are few women in gaming workplaces; that's why there is toxicity in some games... Participation of more women is important," she says. She was also one of the brains behind #SheMeansBusiness, a resource hub created to support women entrepreneurs. In 2013, as a mentor for UN Women on Project Inspire, Sandhya started a programme called "Women in STEM" to encourage girl students to join STEM courses. "It has now become a very large programme called girls pioneers. Around 40,000 girls are introduced to STEM at school," says Sandhya. ■

–Kaushik Deka